



Build a better firewall and the world may upgrade to Vista

Windows Vista is going to include a powerful new 2-way firewall. Will this ...

MATT MONDOK – JAN 23, 2006 9:45 PM |  0

 TEXT SETTINGS

Several Windows Vista features have already been touted as being better than what any of its Windows brethren offer, but one feature that hasn't received much press is the new 2-way firewall. While Windows XP included a firewall, it was not robust enough to filter both incoming and outgoing traffic, with the exception of some ICMP messages. The new Vista firewall appears to be much more advanced compared to its predecessor, which also means that users may have to have a brief understanding of how a firewall works to get it set up properly, barring a simple out-of-the-box configuration that may keep out a few intruders.

Vista's firewall, which is similar to the one currently found in OneCare, will have separate firewall profiles for domains and non-domains, the ability to block incoming and outgoing traffic, a Microsoft Management Console (MMC) user interface, and detailed configuration options. With the capability to set advanced configurations options, network administrators should find this new firewall much more useful than the one currently in Windows XP SP2.

For example, a network administrator can configure the new Windows Firewall with a set of exceptions to block all traffic sent to specific ports, such as the well-known ports used by virus software, or to specific addresses containing either sensitive or undesirable content.

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The Vista firewall looks like everything that the XP firewall should have been. I'm not knocking the XP firewall since it *is* better than no firewall at all, but it best functions as a backup to a much more thorough solution. Vista's inclusion of a more powerful firewall means that users won't have to look to third party software for protection, but what about lowly XP? Will Microsoft possibly include this extended firewall as a part of Windows XP Service Pack 3, assuming that it does get released? Or is the company going to use the feature as a mechanism to lure users into upgrading early?

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